📖 Ethics Overview

This note brings together three PDF presentations that examine **virtue ethics**, **natural law**, and foundational **ethical concepts**, highlighting their philosophical roots, cultural dimensions, and practical applications.

📚 Content Sources

- Section 1: Explores **Virtue Ethics** and **Filipino Values** in a 41-page PDF presentation. (source)
- Section 2: Details **Natural Law** and **Classification of Law** within a 20-page PDF presentation. (source)
- Section 3: Defines **Ethics** and outlines **Ethical Thinking** in a 27-page PDF presentation. (source)

Section 1: Virtue Ethics & Filipino Values 🎯

This section covers Aristotelian virtue ethics and its application to Filipino cultural values from a 41-page presentation (source)

Introduction & Visual Identity

The presentation opens with a stylized graphic of a **cracked number 2** transitioning from yellow through orange, pink, and magenta to black outline—visually signaling this as the second group in a series and indicating building upon previous content.

Learning Objectives 📚

By the end of the session, students should be able to:

#	Objective
1	**Explain** the meaning and basic principles of virtue ethics
2	**Differentiate** between virtuous and non-virtuous acts
3	**Apply** Aristotle's ethical framework to Filipino cultural values

4	**Identify** examples of virtue ethics in everyday Filipino practices

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Classroom Activities 🧩

Ice-breaker: Jigsaw

Students divided into small groups to complete a jigsaw puzzle, fostering **collaboration** and setting the stage for the theme of **community** that recurs throughout.

"Virtue Scenarios Challenge" (Main Activity)

Step	Instruction
1	Form groups of **4-5** participants
2	Each group receives **ONE** jigsaw puzzle
3	Race to complete; finished picture reveals a **KEY TERM** related to virtue ethics
4	Group must **define** the term once visible
5	**First** group to finish **and** correctly explain wins

> This reinforces **practice** and **repetition**—central ideas in virtue ethics.

Foundations of Virtue Ethics 🏛️

Definition

> **Virtue Ethics** is a moral philosophy **focused on character** rather than on rules (deontology) or consequences (consequentialism).

- Asks **"How should I be?"** instead of **"What should I do?"**
- Historically **developed by Aristotle (384-322 BCE)**
- Emphasizes **cultivation of good character traits** through habitual practice
- **Ultimate goal: eudaimonia** — *human flourishing* or a life well-lived

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Aristotle's Four Pillars

Principle	Core Idea	Relevance to Virtue Ethics
Telos (Purpose)	Every being has purpose; for humans: **reasoning well** and living in accord with nature	Provides the *aim* toward which virtuous activity is directed
Eudaimonia (Flourishing)	Highest human good; **life lived through virtue**, distinct from fleeting happiness	The *telos* of human life; end-state virtue ethics strives to achieve
Areté (Excellence/Virtue)	Excellence of character cultivated through repeated practice; includes **moral and intellectual** virtues	The *means* by which one fulfills telos and attains eudaimonia
Agent-Centered	Ethics is **person-oriented**; focus on moral agent's development, not isolated acts	Highlights importance of **stable character** over occasional right actions

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The Golden Mean ⚖️

> **Concept:** Virtue occupies a **mean** between two vices: **excess** and **deficiency**

- **Not a mathematical average** but the **appropriate response** to each particular situation
- **Practical Wisdom (phronesis)** required to discern the correct mean

Virtue	Deficiency (Vice)	Excess (Vice)
Courage	Cowardice	Recklessness
Generosity	Stinginess	Extravagance
Honesty	Deceitfulness	Brutal honesty (over-sharing)

What Makes an Act Virtuous? ✅

A virtuous act must satisfy **four conditions**:

#	Condition	Explanation
1	**Knowledge**	Agent acts with full awareness and understanding of moral significance
2	**Choice**	Act is **deliberately selected** for its own sake, not external reward
3	**Stable Character**	Act stems from **firm, enduring disposition** (a virtue)
4	**Right Timing & Right Way**	Action fits specific context appropriately

> **Critical nuance: One isolated good deed does not confer virtue.** Virtue is a **consistent pattern** of character.

Virtuous vs. Non-Virtuous Acts 🔍

Aspect	Virtuous Acts	Non-Virtuous Acts
Intentionality	Done **knowingly** and **willingly**	Done from **ignorance**, compulsion, or external motives
Motivation	Chosen **for its own sake**	Performed for **rewards, status, or pressure**
Character Reflection	Mirrors **stable, virtuous character**	Shows **inconsistent or flawed** character
Mean	Hits the **golden mean**	Leans toward **excess** or **deficiency**
Contextual Appropriateness	Executed at **right time, in right way**	Misaligned with situation

Example	Helping neighbor **simply because it is right**	Helping neighbor **only to gain favor**

Aristotelian Ethics in Filipino Culture 🇵🇭

Core Filipino Concepts

Filipino Concept	Translation/Explanation	Role in Moral Life
Loób	"Relational will," the **inner authentic self**; seat of moral consciousness	Source of **authentic action**; aligns with Aristotle's focus on *stable character*
Kapwa	"Shared self," seeing others as extensions of oneself	Basis for **communal ethics**; emphasizes relational responsibility

> **Contrast with Aristotle:** While Aristotle's eudaimonia is **individual** (flourishing of the person), Filipino eudaimonia is **communal**, rooted in welfare of the group.

Six Core Filipino Virtues

#	Virtue	Description
1	**Kapwa (Shared Identity)**	Recognizing others as part of oneself; foundational to Filipino ethics
2	**Bayanihan (Community Spirit)**	Collective helping; cooperation toward common good
3	**Utang na Loob (Debt of Gratitude)**	Reciprocity; honoring those who have helped you
4	**Pakikipagkapwa (Fellowship)**	Active engagement and building meaningful connections
5	**Hiya (Sense of Propriety)**	Awareness of social appropriateness;

		maintaining harmony
6	**Pagpapakatao (Being Human)**	Acting with dignity, respect, and humanity toward others

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Everyday Filipino Practices as Virtue Applications

Practice	Virtuous Dimension	How It Mirrors the Golden Mean
Mano po (respectful greeting to elders)	Honors **respect** without demeaning oneself; balances humility and dignity	Hits mean between **over-subservience** and **disrespect**
Pakikisama (getting along, smooth interpersonal relations)	Promotes **social harmony** while allowing authentic expression	Avoids extremes of **conflict** and **false conformity**
Helping family succeed (family-oriented support)	Shows **generosity** and **responsibility** without sacrificing personal well-being	Balances **self-sacrifice** (deficiency) and **over-indulgence** (excess)
"Sama-sama tayo" (collective decision-making)	Encourages **participation** and **shared responsibility**	Prevents **authoritarianism** (excess) and **anarchy** (deficiency)

> These repeated cultural habits **train character** (habitual practice) and foster **communal flourishing**, directly echoing Aristotle's view that virtues are formed through *repeated action*.

Virtue Ethics in Research (BSIT Students) 🔬

- **Character-Based Research Ethics:** Beyond mere compliance with rules, researchers should embody virtues such as **honesty**, **rigor**, and **respect**
- **Filipino Values as Ethical Enhancers:**

Value	Application in Research

Kapwa	Treat participants as fellow humans; foster empathy
Respect	Honor dignity of subjects and collaborators
Integrity (Loób)	Remain true to authentic self; avoid data manipulation

- **Outcome:** A research project that **reflects the researcher's character**, contributing to both **personal and societal eudaimonia**

Key Takeaways 📝

#	Takeaway
1	**Virtue ethics prioritizes character development** over isolated actions
2	The **Golden Mean** offers a practical tool for balancing extremes in behavior
3	**Virtuous acts** arise from a **stable, knowledgeable, and willingly-chosen** character
4	**Filipino cultural values** (Loób, Kapwa, and six core virtues) align with Aristotle's framework, but **focus on communal flourishing** rather than individualistic eudaimonia
5	Consistent practice of virtues—whether in daily life or academic research—**cultivates the character needed for true human flourishing**

Assessment: 15-Item Identification Quiz 📝

#	Prompt	Expected Answer
1	The ultimate goal of human life according to Aristotle,	**Eudaimonia**

	often translated as "flourishing."	
2	The Greek term for excellence or virtue in Aristotle's ethics.	**Areté**
3	The principle that virtue lies between two extremes of excess and deficiency.	**The Golden Mean**
4	Aristotle's term for practical wisdom needed to discern virtuous action.	**Phrónēsis**
5	The human function or purpose, which Aristotle identifies as reasoning.	**Telos**
6	Filipino concept meaning "relational will" or authentic inner self.	**Loób**
7	Filipino concept meaning "shared self" or seeing others as part of oneself.	**Kapwa**
8	Filipino value of collective helping and community spirit.	**Bayanihan**
9	The vice of having too much courage, beyond the golden mean.	**Recklessness**
10	The vice of having too little courage, below the golden mean.	**Cowardice**
11	Filipino concept of debt of gratitude and reciprocity.	**Utang na Loob**
12	Type of ethics that focuses on character rather than actions.	**Virtue Ethics**

13	The stable disposition or character trait from which virtuous actions flow.	**Virtue** (or **Stable Character**)
14	Filipino virtue of maintaining social appropriateness and harmony.	**Hiya**
15	The characteristic that makes Aristotle's ethics "agent-centered" rather than "act-centered."	**Focus on the moral agent's character**

Closing

The presentation concludes with a **Thank-You slide** inviting **questions and discussion**, encouraging participants to reflect on how virtue ethics can be lived out in personal, cultural, and academic contexts.

Section 2: Natural Law & Other Laws ⚖️

This section covers St. Thomas Aquinas's classification of law and natural law principles from a 20-page presentation (source)

Presentation Overview

Element	Details
Title	*Natural Law & Other Laws*
Presented By	Group 3
Structure	Two main topics: (1) **Classification of Law** and (2) **Principles of Natural Law**
Repeated Motifs	"Ice Breaker Time" and "Thank You" appear at opening and closing

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Why Classifying Law Matters?

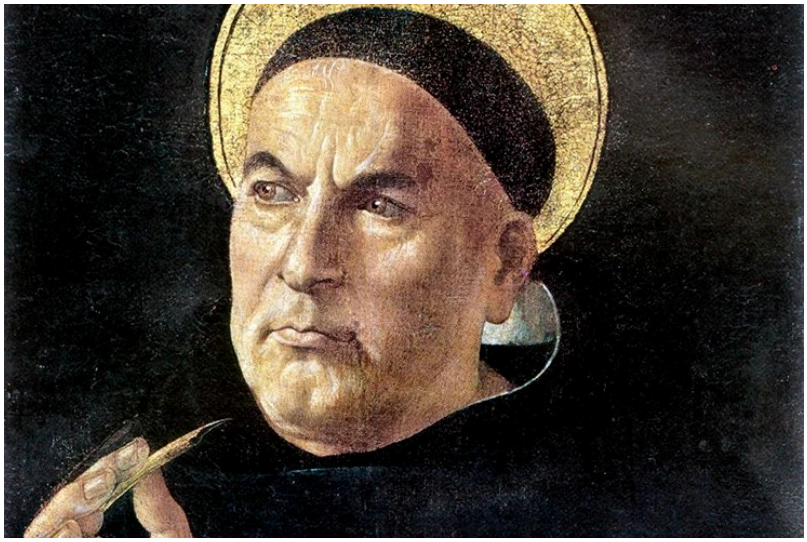
The presentation opens with the question **"Why classifying law matters?"** (shown twice), establishing an implicit argument: understanding the **different tiers of law** helps clarify their **sources, authority, and inter-relationships**, which in turn guides **moral reasoning and legal practice**.

What Is Law?

The slide **"What is law?"** (also shown twice) sets the stage for a **hierarchical view of legal concepts**, leading into Aquinas's four-tier model.

St. Thomas Aquinas – The Thinker Behind the Model 👤

Detail	Information
Influence	Greatly influenced by **Aristotle**
Title	"Universal Doctor of the Church"
Birth	1225, Roccasecca, Italy
Death	7 March 1274, Fossanova Abbey, Italy
Education	Studied at a Benedictine house in Naples
Father	**Landulf**, count of Aquino, nephew of Emperor Frederick Barbarossa
Mother	**Theodora Rossi**, countess of Teano, descendant of a Norman baron



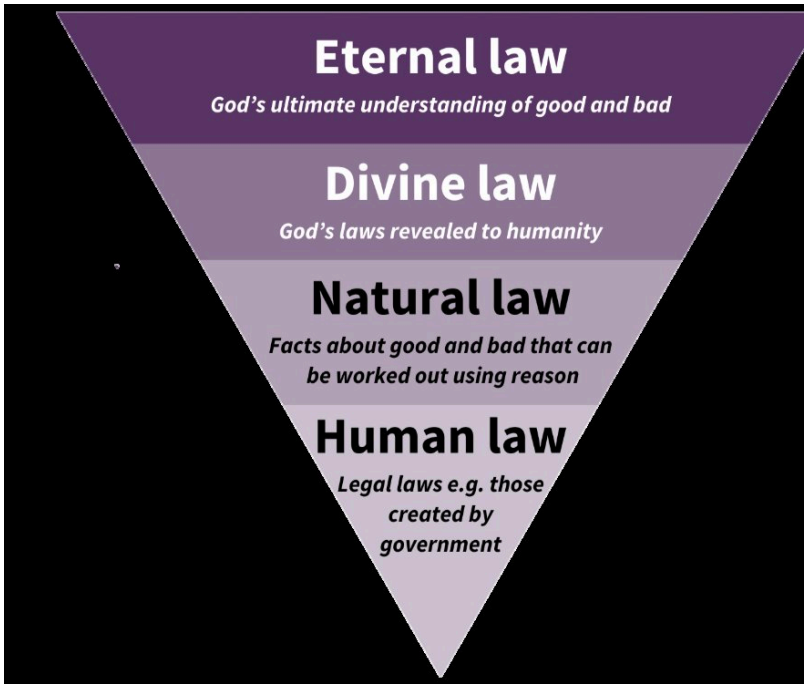
The close-up shows a man with a gold halo, black hat and garment, holding a quill. The contemplative expression underscores Aquinas's reputation as a learned theologian and philosopher.

Aquinas's Four Kinds of Law 📊

The Law Pyramid

Aquinas proposes a **four-level pyramid** where each tier **derives its authority from the tier above it**.

Hierarchy (top → bottom): Eternal Law → Divine Law → Natural Law → Human (Positive) Law



The purple pyramid set against a black background visually maps the hierarchical relationship Aquinas describes.

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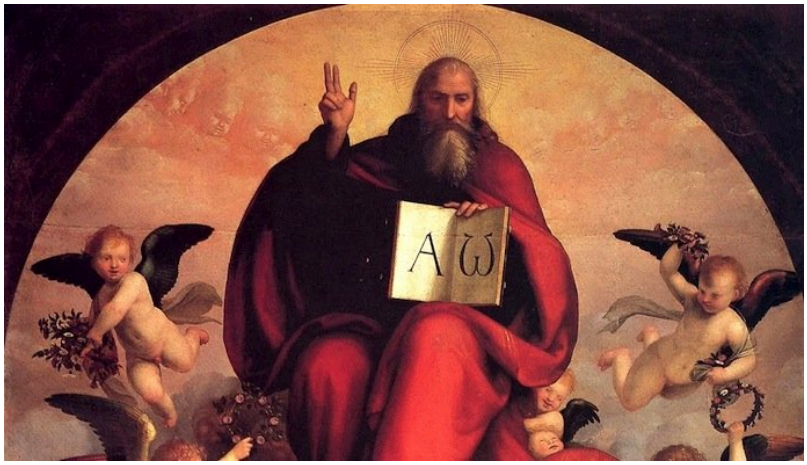
1. Eternal Law ⭐

> **Definition:** God's divine plan and wisdom that governs the entire universe.

Characteristics:

- Ultimate rule and measure of all actions and creation

- Originates from God's reason → **unchanging, timeless, perfect**



The majestic figure reinforces the concept of an eternal, divine source of order.

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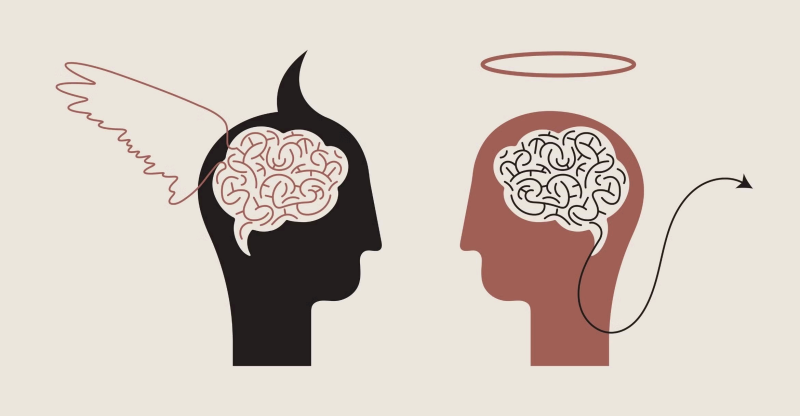
2. Natural Law 🧠

> **Definition:** Human participation in Eternal Law **through reason**.

Key Idea: A moral law "imprinted" in human nature that enables us to discern good from evil.



The contrasting brain imagery underscores the innate capacity to recognize moral truths—a core claim of natural law.

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3. Divine Law ✝️

> **Definition:** Law that **originates from God** and is revealed to humanity through sacred scripture and religious teaching.

Functions:

- Expresses God's will, offering moral guidance **beyond human reason alone**
- Directs humans toward **spiritual fulfillment and eternal salvation**
- Governs outward actions **and** inner intentions, conscience, and the soul's moral condition

The luminous depiction of Christ conveys the idea of divine law being a revealed, transcendent moral authority.

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4. Human (Positive) Law 📜

> **Definition:** Laws formally enacted by legitimate human authorities (governments, legislatures).

Process: Human reason **applies general moral principles** (derived from higher tiers) to concrete social situations.

Functions:

- Regulates behavior, protects rights, defines duties
- Imposes penalties to maintain order and justice

Relationship Among the Four Kinds 🔗

> **"Each tier of law is derived from the tier above it."**

This cascade illustrates a **theological-legal hierarchy**: Eternal → Divine → Natural → Human, showing how secular legislation should ultimately reflect divine and natural moral order.

Principles of Natural Law (Topic 2) 📋

The presentation lists **seven principles** foundational to natural law:

Principle	Core Statement	Supporting Explanation
Survival Principle	*Self-preservation is basic to all beings*	All beings naturally preserve themselves; suicide is "unnatural and immoral"
Action Principle	*Do good and avoid evil*	Humans naturally inclined to survive, reproduce, socialize, seek truth/God; actions contrary violate innate self-preservation
Life Principle	*Human life is inviolable*	Humans driven to procreate and flourish; intentionally blocking life without serious reason opposes natural purpose
Propagation Principle	*All species propagate for self-propagation*	Drive to reproduce underlies species continuity; natural law imperative
Morality Principle	*Built-in natural law governs morality of human thinking and behavior*	Forms foundation of person's moral compass
Social Principle	*Humans as social beings live in peace and harmony*	

	with others	

🎯 Putting it All Together

🌱 Core Moral Foundations

- **Virtue Ethics** – *"How should I be?"* – focuses on **character** cultivated through habitual practice, aiming at **eudaimonia** (human flourishing).

> *Virtue ethics is a moral philosophy focused on character rather than rules or consequences.*

- **Natural Law** – human reason participates in **Eternal Law**, yielding a universal moral order that guides **positive (human) law**.

> *Natural law is the rational participation of humans in the divine plan, allowing us to discern good from evil.*

- **General Ethics** – provides the **terminology, branches, and analytical tools** (e.g., consequentialism, deontology, rights ethics) that structure moral reasoning across personal, social, professional, and political spheres.

These three streams converge on the idea that **reasonable agents** must align actions with a **higher purpose**—whether it is Aristotle's telos, Aquinas's eternal law, or the normative standards of contemporary ethical theory.

⚖️ Comparative Snapshot

Dimension	Virtue Ethics (Aristotle)	Natural Law (Aquinas)	Broad Ethical Theories
Primary Question	*Who should I become?*	*How does reason reflect divine order?*	*What makes an action right?*
Key Concepts	Golden Mean, phronesis, eudaimonia	Eternal → Divine → Natural → Human law; 7 moral principles	Consequentialism, deontology, rights, care, casuistry

Source of Normativity	Human **character** developed by habit	**Reason** + **divine revelation**	Varies: outcomes, duties, virtues, rights
Role of Community	Emphasizes **shared practices** (e.g., *bayanihan*)	Law hierarchy culminates in **social order**	Ethics of care / communitarianism foregrounds relationships

🌍 Cultural & Contextual Integration

- **Filipino virtues** (kapwa, bayanihan, hiya, etc.) instantiate the **Golden Mean** in everyday life—balancing generosity with self-care, courage with prudence.
- These values **mirror** Aquinas's view that **human law should reflect natural law**, because communal practices embody the moral principles (preservation, social harmony, truth-seeking) outlined in the natural-law framework.
- The **"Loób"** concept aligns with Aristotle's emphasis on **stable character**: an authentic inner self guides virtuous choices, just as the virtuous agent must act *knowingly* and *willingly*.

🛠️ Practical Applications

- **Research Ethics (BSIT focus)** – blend **honesty, rigor, and respect** (virtue ethics) with **kapwa** (shared humanity) and **natural-law principles** (preserve life, seek truth).
- **Professional Conduct** – apply **rights ethics** (non-negotiable protections) alongside **virtue-based integrity** and **natural-law's social principle** (peaceful coexistence).
- **Everyday Decisions** – use the **Golden Mean** to navigate conflicts (e.g., speaking truthfully without brutal honesty), guided by the **knowledge-freedom-will** triad required for moral responsibility.

📚 Integrated Takeaways

- **Reasoned character** is the common thread: whether cultivated through habitual virtue, participation in divine reason, or systematic ethical analysis, the moral agent must develop a stable disposition.
- **Hierarchy of norms**—from eternal principles to human statutes—provides a scaffold for aligning **personal virtues**, **cultural practices**, and **legal frameworks**.
- **Context matters**: while universal principles (e.g., preservation of life) set the baseline, **cultural relativism** and **contextual ethics** ensure that application respects local norms without compromising core moral goods.